Article 3

Political Philosophy Is Useless for the Study of Servers

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Abstract

Players of sandbox games in virtual worlds are often inclined to think that the same social phenomena that spring up in real life are applicable to player-to-player interactions in game; further, that these interactions are often governed by broader moral or ethical principles that reflect those of the real world. Thus, for many it makes sense to apply political philosophy to these games, since they appear to give us a window into how these systems spring up in the real world. Minecraft is perhaps the clearest example; because of its open-ended structure, players consider it to be an ideal environment for simulating and theorizing about political communities. However, I will argue that insofar as Minecraft presupposes ideal conditions which players must then constrain themselves, political philosophy can only engage in a descriptive, not normative, role in the study of communities on Minecraft servers.

3.1 Introduction

Minecraft servers are interesting in myriad ways, not least due to the fact that we tend to think that they provide insights into how people behave under peculiar circumstances. Insofar as we think this to be the case, we are also tempted to make prescriptions for how those people *ought* to behave. To engage in a community is not just to engage in a descriptive project, in which the practices of the community are described and represented in detail, but also to engage in a normative one in which a certain level of institutional development and social coherence is needed to ensure that things are in order within

the community. Surely there would be few who would say that these assumptions are unreasonable; and from them we may be tempted to derive the notion that our ways of understanding what prescriptions we are beholden to in the real world, especially those that pertain to the political sphere, may also apply to communities broadly; Minecraft servers being no exception. Hence, our tendency to apply political philosophy to virtual worlds.

I will argue here, however, that many of these intuitions are mistaken; that, in fact, most of the questions with which political philosophy deals are scarcely of importance for understanding what goes on in Minecraft servers (though the case may be made for other games, I will limit the scope of this argument to Minecraft). In essence, political philosophy aims to generate normative prescriptions that apply to political societies, i.e., prescriptions that apply both to authorities (if one believes the set of legitimate authorities to be nonempty), and to people following those authorities. These prescriptions are motivated by real-world constraints, while communities in Minecraft are not so constrained; the place of political philosophy in Minecraft is thus *posterior*, rather than *anterior*, to what people ought to do; for political philosophy usually only serves to present what is possible to the players in terms of the kind of situation they would like to find themselves in rather than as a legitimate, normatively-binding force that acts upon them. Whatever normatively binding forces actually exist, exist on the level of *individuals* rather than on the level of a political community.

3.2 The purview of political philosophy

3.2.1 Resource distribution

In the first place, much of political philosophy is centered around how to distribute resources fairly. There are competing views, even prior to strictly political ones, as to how adequate distributions are to be achieved. Pure egalitarians argue that resources should be distributed equally across the population without exception. Luck egalitarians argue much the same and hold that differences in outcomes across individuals should be a function only of any given individual's own choices. Prioritarians argue that benefits given to the least well-off should be weighed more than those given to those better-off. (Parfit, 1997) There are, of course, different ethical theories that provide justification for various political theories. The prioritarian, for example, may be motivated by the utilitarian consideration that one should aim to maximize the amount of good done for the greatest number of individuals, which means giving benefits to the least well-off. Others may not be moved by utilitarianism and instead view the consequences of an action simply as a reason, yet not a *final* reason for doing something. In Anscombe's example, (Anscombe, 1967) five people are stranded on one island and one person on another; you manage to spot both islands and decide to save the one person. The five people, according to Anscombe, do not have a claim to having been *wronged*; for someone was indeed saved, and the rescuer did not decide *not* to save anyone. She discusses another example, more explicitly related to the distribution of resources. One

person suffers from a fatal illness, and a group of five suffer from the same illness. A single vial of an antidote is available; except the former person requires the entire vial to be cured, and the latter five each require one-fifth of the vial to be cured. No-one is wronged, Anscombe concludes, if one decides to give the one person the entire vial rather than saving the five. Is this a fair use of resources? Now, political considerations are, at bottom, ethical considerations. But there is disagreement with respect to how one moves from the ethical to the political. A plausible answer is that the ethical becomes the political when resources are involved on a sufficient scale—viz., when certain patterns of distribution may be considered more just than others. Whatever normative prescriptions follow, then, aim to achieve such distributions.

What we should note at this point is not strictly anything having to do with the individual views given here. Rather, we should note that the central aim of ethics is to remedy an existing state of affairs, call this A, via some theory so as to achieve a fairer, more just state of affairs; call this B. Different views have different verdicts on how to get from A to B, and what B would actually look like. Some, such as Anscombe, do not believe B to be wholly determined by the consequences of actions, and thus does not necessarily prescribe that B, for a good ethical theory, always supervenes on consequences. Others, such as Parfit, would disagree. (Parfit, 1984) One of the plausible, though perhaps not exhaustive, ways in which a view can conceive this move from mere ethical prescriptions to talk of the political (taken in the philosophical sense) is in terms of the distribution of resources.

In Minecraft servers, however, things work differently. Assuming we examine a vanilla server in its infancy, its initial conditions are starkly different than any "initial" state of affairs in the real-world. Players are hidden behind a Rawlsian "veil of ignorance", in which their physical real-world characteristics are largely stripped away and only their in-game capabilities and knowledge remain.[a] (Rawls, 1971, p. 10) The distribution of resources, moreover, is nominally equal. The Rawlsian metaphor here breaks down, as we cannot benefit the least well-off having assumed the veil of ignorance if the distribution of resources past a certain point is scarcely of importance. Of course, there may exist a scarcity of *labor*;[b] but there is little one cannot acquire with reasonable effort. Others have noticed this feature of the game, and many agree that the player is almost completely autonomous resource-wise. What are the possibilities, then, if one wants to make a server interesting? The traditional problems that drop out from the assumptions of real-world political philosophy do not really drop out in the case of Minecraft. Theoretically, each player can act autonomously resource-wise, and questions concerning how to distribute resources fairly do not arise. We are missing, however, the fact that this is precisely why political philosophy does not have any *normative* pull in Minecraft, at least in the case of resource distribution. For the good server owner knows that an effective way to motivate interest in a server is to *create* problems. The server owner may place

[a] Of course, their mental capacities, memories, previous relationships, etc., still remain. What matters is that each player has the capacity to affect and derive resources from the world similarly, which is not so in the real world.

[b] I'm indebted to Snorka for this observation.

borders on the world so as to limit the number of resources available; cap the number of valuable items in circulation; limit movement within a region to force cooperation; etc. It is only here that the traditional problems pop out. Indeed, if, for example, the world border is limited, one has to figure out the ideal distribution. But because such artificial constraints can only be generated by presupposing what the ideal distribution actually is (i.e., something like a server's unaltered state where players are completely resource-autonomous), the solution is already baked into the design. While real-world political philosophy is indeterminate as to what the ideal state of affairs (B) would look like from the perspective of a determinate state of affairs (A), a Minecraft server has to *create* indeterminacy by presupposing what the ideal conditions are and subsequently imposing constraints. Political philosophy, then, is only useful for people invested in the server insofar as the ones in charge of the server use it to *design* the server, rather than provide normative prescriptions for those within it. At that point, however, it ceases being political philosophy.

Political philosophy gets its normativity precisely because the state of affairs towards which it aims is indeterminate and hazy. We *ought* to do X in part because the possibility of X coming about is a *possibility*, not an actuality. We cannot say that one *ought* to do something given that the state of affairs with which they are charged with realizing has already come about.[a] In server design, by contrast, the tools political philosophy has at its disposal can only be cashed out in terms of *descriptions*. When the server owner imposes a world border, given what we know about what is valuable in the game, what the players ought to do is a foregone conclusion. We can only observe them going through the motions of playing within the world, knowing what the optimal decision procedures are for them already given the constraints. Now, the claim is not that the players are completely predictable; of course, players often do things they ought not to do (e.g., killing other players, griefing, hoarding, etc.), but that is not what is at stake here. The claim is that normative prescriptions cease being interesting as the *raison d'etre* of a community when the structures that organize that community already presuppose what people ought to do in the first place. Political philosophy in this case becomes an *explanation* for a state of affairs, rather than a guide for action so as to reach a different state of affairs.

3.2.2 The state

Take another salient topic in political philosophy: namely, the ideal position and configuration of the state. This is an issue with a distinguished history; its first true treatments may be found in Plato and Aristotle. The former thought the ideal form of political organization to consist of philosopher-rulers who, having been trained to seek truth and inquire into the nature of things (via the Forms), would be the best suited to manage a polity. (Plato, 1968) The latter (who was not terribly keen on the Forms) was concerned

[a] N.B. This is distinct from normative prescriptions which say that one ought to *repeat* certain actions so as to bring a certain state of affairs about continuously (e.g., continuously donating one tenth of your wealth to charity). The claim here pertains only to past states of affairs, which cannot be altered.

with the structure and size of the state as much as he was with what it ought to do. Should we have a monarch, in which only one individual rules, an aristocracy in which only a few rule, or a constitution[a] in which the majority rule? Aristotle (2008) thought a benevolent king to be the most ideal, though a constitution to be the most practical and just. Others were concerned with the function and limits of the state. Should the state wield unlimited power, or should it have checks and balances? Should we accept the latter, what kinds of checks should we impose? Hobbes was willing to accept the former; (Hobbes, 1994) others like Montesquieu and Nozick the latter. Sovereignty may be something that, by virtue of its nature, is indivisible—where any division in the power of the sovereign may lead us to suppose that whatever entities exist after the division are not sovereign at all. Given that an undivided, all-powerful sovereign is a preferable sort of political organization to an anarchic state of nature, we should opt for the former. This is the essence of Hobbes's argument. Nozick is a good foil; for he argues that the sole permissible functions of the state are to enforce contracts and protect its subjects. (Nozick, 1974) Beyond this point, the state is morally unjustified in doing anything further. Others believe that the state should not exist at all, or at least that there are no legitimate authorities.

Again, the important thing to note here is that the normative prescriptions we put to states, whether it be with respect to its size, limits, or constitution, are a product of constraint. Political philosophers argue that we ought to move from one state of affairs to another, given the inadequacy of the preceding state of affairs. Minecraft, by contrast, can always *be* adequate. We cannot prescribe how a state should look like in the game so much as one willingly and consciously participates in its construction. There is no *normative* pull. If we want a particular sort of state to arise in the game, we must make the conditions suitable for its realization. We would not be concerned with what we ought to do in order to realize high-level goods, e.g., maximizing the satisfaction of the players, setting up the right kind of state, or distributing resources in the most efficient manner; for the best way to do that, presumably, is to let everyone run amok and do whatever they wish. Because of the game's design as a sandbox, such ends are already built into the game. Minecraft is *already* a maximizing tool, since, *ceteris paribus*, it lets the player do whatever they want. Whatever political constraints there are appear to be artificial and scarcely normative. The place of political philosophy, then, if there is any, is in the realm of *institutional design*; of designing certain situations so as to achieve certain objectives and outcomes. Its place is not in offering us any novelties about what we ought to do in certain situations, since the game, at least politically, already gives us solutions.

[a] Aristotle used the term "democracy" to refer to the degenerate form of a constitution, in which the tyranny of the majority prevails. One may think of a "constitution" as something like a just, modern-day democracy. Additionally, for the three "just" versions of the possible configurations of the state, Aristotle posits an "unjust" mirror image of each of those forms; namely: *tyranny* for monarchy, *oligarchy* for aristocracy, and *democracy* for the constitution.

3.3 Ethics, generally considered

Now, in addition to this claim I also sought to claim something else; namely, that whatever normative prescriptions we *can* cash out of Minecraft servers, occur on the level of individuals rather than political communities. More specifically, normative ethics as applied to individuals still holds up in the presence of changes in institutional design. We have observed that a political community in Minecraft must in large part be designed so as to achieve certain specifications and objectives; for such communities would not otherwise have arisen. Normative relations between individuals, however, are scarcely so designed. Although changes in an external situation can enforce certain changes on the entirety of a community, the relations between individuals do not necessarily change character as a result; normative prescriptions between them still have the same character. For example, if it is generally permitted on a server for players to kill each other, this does not necessarily make it morally permissible for individuals to kill each other in turn. I may still have an obligation to my friend to refrain from killing them as far as killing them would cause them harm in-game (and in certain exceptional circumstances, in the real world). But the institutional design of the server has no bearing whatsoever on whether my killing my friend is permissible or impermissible. What institutional design can do is make certain actions more or less *acceptable*; for what matters in the case of institutional design is upholding the design itself, not necessarily maximizing a good. Hence breaking or following certain precepts may gain or lose one repute or respect. But this has no real normative import. If one desired to implement a monarchical system on a server, the question of whether the monarchy is, in fact, implemented can be pulled apart entirely from whether this arrangement benefits the players substantially. This is completely unlike the real world, wherein the maintenance of a state of affairs indeed has a direct bearing on the well-being of its participants.

To clarify: suppose that considerations of institutional design led us to desire the realization of a pattern, P, within a server. We may also suppose that the purpose of a server is to complete some objective, O, where O takes into account in some measure the well-being of the participants, or some other ethically relevant aspect of the participants' experience in the server. The claim is that O is not necessarily dependent on the mere realization, or process of realizing P. For the relation is actually inverted; depending on the objective of the server, the institutional design will reflect that objective. P, in fact, depends on O; and this dependence prefigures the relevant politico-philosophical precepts that account for what people ought to do once this pattern is established. Hence, any deviation from P can be accounted for by the fact that it may just reflect O more satisfactorily. Ethics *in general*, as it applies to the individual player, *can* figure in since that is precisely what determines the shape of O. It is important not to conflate such prescriptions with politico-philosophical ones. It still makes perfect logical sense, for instance, to talk about the aggregate utility of a group of agents without invoking the state or authority in general, and consequentialist and nonconsequentialist ethics without patterns of resource distribution.

These conclusions are intuitively absurd. However, I am not claiming that political philosophy is useless in Minecraft in general. Rather, I am claiming that it is not useful when we consider the study of human behavior in Minecraft servers specifically. Of course, were Minecraft like the real world to a high degree of accuracy, it would certainly be useful. But presumably the study of these pockets of human interaction is not the study of what individuals *ought* to do, but rather of *what* they do. What they ought to do can only be cashed out at the level of the individual, as far as they are charged with the presence of other players with whom they interact. But when it comes to the general design of the server in which they find themselves, any large-scale normative prescriptions that could hope to approximate anything that real-world political philosophy would offer vanish—and for the simple reason that one can theoretically realize whatever state of affairs they want within the game.

3.4 Concluding thoughts

What we find interesting about applying political philosophy to Minecraft is not, as our intuitions may tell us enticingly, the fact that we find moral prescriptions for what people should do under certain circumstances. Rather, what we find interesting is isolating certain facets of human behavior that we know to be present *already* and seeing them play out in real time without real-world consequences. Political philosophy cannot provide anything for the game for precisely this reason. When designing servers, or places where people coexist in general, one must inevitably come up against a form of the old Hegelian problem that a movement of a state of affairs is not necessary but *imposes* its necessity. In Minecraft servers, the ethical never becomes the political; for the political is imposed, not made.

3.5 Declarations

No conflict of interest and no AI use have been declared.

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Article 4

The removal of agency by server owners and reclaiming player power

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Abstract

Throughout the history of Minecraft servers, there is one system that has remained the same: leadership. At the top is the server's owner, the person who has the final say in any decision made; next are the server's admins, a group of people whom the owner trusts to act on their behalf; finally, there are the moderators, who enforce the server's rules and maintain conduct in the day-to-day running of the server. I call this the Traditional structure. This paper argues that this structure is fundamentally flawed by exploring the core function and purpose of a Minecraft server, which is to create *satisfaction* for players on the server. Two key terms are outlined: *agency* and *power*, which are important for understanding why the Traditional structure has and continues to fail players by examining the issue from the perspective of the Player. This paper considers the individual *player* and the lone decision-maker – the owner – as classes in a hierarchy to better understand the inter-class interactions, removing individual anomalies in behaviour and allowing readers to understand the problem at a higher level. Finally, this paper proposes a structure where Players (as a class) have no "need" for the Owner, as decisions would only be made by Players.

4.1 Introduction

The rigid Owner-Player hierarchy found in Traditional structures has created the most (monetarily) successful servers in the world (e.g., Hypixel, Mineplex, and Donut SMP). Both Raid Farms and Minecraft Bloodlines (MCB), the most studied and influential

servers in the field of Minecraft Server Theory (MST), have this rigid top-down structure of power. It can appear logical, even ideal, to have a few people at the top dictating the direction of the server and viewing players as numbers and statistics needing improvement.

Such hierarchical systems do not exist in isolation, but in the context of everything around their creators. Just like the most popular Minecraft servers, the most well-known real-life corporations also follow this kind of hierarchy – Amazon, Nestle, and Tesla to name a few.

I will argue in this paper that this hierarchical structure fails to achieve its goal, even when one thinks solely about higher and higher player counts. To understand why, one must also reframe one's thinking of the meaning of "success" for a server, which I argue should be in terms of *player satisfaction* instead of other numerical metrics. Following this, one must also understand that the Traditional structure fails to meet this goal and is also the reason why the vast majority of servers fail after the Two-Week Phase. I will discuss an alternative way of thinking about player satisfaction, and by extension, the success of a server. Moreover, having understood why the Traditional structure fails and how a different view should be adopted, I will discuss how the same structure deals with player suggestions and change. I will argue that the unilateral nature of the Owner means that Players are not satisfied, resulting in the eventual collapse in feelings of excitement for the server's potential. Finally, I will lay out a better structure of leadership which holds Player satisfaction at its core and would yield a more "successful" server.

In this paper, all mentions of "server" can be assumed to mean a *Survival Multiplayer (SMP)* server. An SMP is best defined in its components, which includes but is not limited to:

- Survival gamemode
- Multiplayer
- Focused on player-to-player interaction
- An open and expansive world for players to do as they wish

4.1.1 Use of "satisfaction" in this paper

The word *satisfaction* is used throughout this paper instead of *fun* as, ironically, what gives players *satisfaction* may not always be *fun*. Take the example of fighting the Ender Dragon. It is a difficult fight for the typical player, and one may die several times during the fight. This is by no means an activity that can objectively and easily be considered *fun*, but it brings about satisfaction in that the player continues to engage in the activity and has fun in the end. One can consider satisfaction to be fun in hindsight, where even if a player struggled during a difficult part of the game, as long as they came out of it for the better, they can think *in hindsight* that they *did* have fun.

4.2 Existing structures and hierarchies

The current mainstream leadership structure is roughly similar to the following:

> (In descending order of power)
>
> Owner > Admin > Moderator > Player

As explained in the next section, this structure is inefficient in achieving player satisfaction. However, we must first discuss *how* this structure works in practice and *why* it sometimes creates a successful server.

The Owner[a] holds the most power in a server and all decisions must be made with their approval. As they hold control of the Minecraft server (and usually also the Discord server that they might have), only *they* can make changes. Even if it is a decision that a majority of the leadership team (that is, the Admins and possibly the Moderators, together with the Owner) supports, only the Owner is able to actually install a mod or change the game difficulty, for example. This means they have complete autocratic control over all things, even if they are amicable and adhere to the majority rule. Thus, I think it is less pertinent to discuss the roles of the Admins and Moderators, as their power is ultimately given by the Owner.

If a real-life example can aid your understanding, take the United Kingdom – the King is the *de facto* head of state. Any law passed by both the Houses of Commons and Lords must be signed off by the King so that it may become the official law of the land. Without his rubber stamp, any law coming onto his desk will not be in effect, even if the entire country supports it.[b]

This is completely and undoubtedly dangerous. The high concentration of power, the selection of the next leader by the current leader, and the leader's failure to understand the experiences of ordinary people compound into a dangerous slope toward detachment from reality.

Why must an Owner, who is not elected, not chosen, and cannot be held accountable through any means (as they have the ultimate say and can completely disregard all dissent), control the entire server? Or really, in concrete terms – how does this ensure player satisfaction?

In a typical SMP server founded between friends, one of them will be the Owner who has likely initiated the idea, owning the physical server that the world is hosted on. Initially, the Owner may decide to ask their Players what kinds of mods and mechanics they would want present on the server. Thereafter, some players may request a change, and others may disagree with the requested change. The Owner acts as a mediator in these cases to make a quick decision based on their own opinion to move the conversation forwards, as they simply want to have fun with their friends. Here, maintaining a strict democratic decision-making process is not necessary as the goal is not to boost player

[a] *Owner* and other terms are capitalised as I am talking about the institution and the class of person, not specifically the person who embodies the role. This distinction is important as the things I talk about are *inherent* to the role and will not change depending on *who* is in that specific office.

[b] Parliament can, using specific laws, force legislation to be approved.

satisfaction and increase the regular player count; instead, the owner is part of a group of friends who use their server as a *medium* to interact and spend time together.

In other words, disagreements in terms of gameplay mechanics can be taken less seriously due to the server's goal, so having efficient and unilateral decision-making is good. Unilateral decision-making may also be more beneficial if all players already know each other before starting to play – which means discussion and compromise is more likely to be fruitful.

One may raise the issue that the server's goal might have been influenced or introduced by the players at the beginning of the server, which means that even if the owner unilaterally makes executive decisions, it still follows the intention set by the players at the beginning.

This is true; however, we must remember that goals and ideas shift over time. A player who suggests, for example, the Copper Rails mod to be installed on the server as they believe it will increase the uses of copper may later find, after using it for a while, that it actually decreases the incentive to mine for gold and iron. Here, their opinion on copper rails may change, but yet, they have no power to change the fact that the mod is installed.

In order for a server to have broad appeal, ensuring player satisfaction *and* increasing its regular player count, two things must be considered: player *agency* and player *power*.

I shall define *agency* as follows:

> Agency can be thought of as a player's inward feeling about whether they have the power to bring about change effectively on a server—which is a standard definition.

Power, however, has nuance to its definition in this context, which I shall define as follows:

> Typically, power is thought of as something which is direct, physical (or mental), or radical. However, power can come in many different ways. This can be power to speak up to a person with more power (e.g., the Owner), power to influence other players, power to enact practical change, and power to simply have one's opinion heard.

Let us first explore a simplified scenario involving a new player who initially enjoys a server but ultimately decides to leave.

First, the player is intrigued by something on the server. If we take the example of Raid Farms, this may be its famous wheat currency. They join the server and they are engaged with this mechanic. As time passes, they notice more things about the new mechanic that they previously hadn't, continuing to make them more and more enthused.

Then, the player inevitably finds a mechanic that they are not the most pleased with. Sticking with our example, the enchanting system has been a large topic of interest and discussion. At this point, the player feels a lot of agency to be *able* to do this as they have a positive view of the server overall, but not yet a lot of power in seeing real change or feedback.

Next, our newly joined but already dedicated player wants to change their new favourite server for the better. They make a suggestion in the server and find that many agree with them. Here, their feeling of agency continues to rise as their power to bring about change is affirmed. They also begin to feel more power as they seem to have invited many people who agree with them, rallying for the change.

The Owner notices this, agrees, and listens to their feedback. We see the peak of both agency and power here: agency is felt by those who feel strongly about this issue when the highest authority on the server affirms that their concerns are valid, and power is felt because they managed to influence this person, who is seen as a role model.

Finally, when the change is implemented, the player might feel unsatisfied, especially if the implementation does not meet their expectations. The change may not have been implemented perfectly, or it may even just require one or two more tweaks. However, at this point, the player's agency is completely shattered as they feel that they are not heard, and thus, did not bring about the change they desired.

Not all players decide to leave immediately after this, but it is very likely that some might. We should also remember that our dedicated new joiner would not leave at this point, as they feel a sense of *loyalty* to the server, but the vast majority of players view a server as a product to be consumed, not an institution or organisation deserving protection, advancement, and dedication.[a]

In terms of looking at agency and power for player satisfaction, the breaking point occurred when the Owner, being this perceived bastion of power and being the ultimate decision-maker, went against the wishes of the players. The players' individual belief that the Owner knows what is best for the server, and what steps to take in order to reach their goal, has been shattered as they *themselves* put the Owner on this pedestal.

One may argue that the fault is not in having an Owner but in the beliefs of the Players. However, this ignores the context in which the Players exist – one where the Owner places themselves in this position of power and status, almost asking to be admired for their apparent wisdom. Players simply follow this expectation that the Owner must be looked up to – creating the situation we find ourselves in.

4.3 Pleasing the players

Now that we've discussed what typical mainstream servers have as their hierarchy of power, and the feelings of agency and power individual players have, we shall shift focus to the Players as a group.

Say that you are the owner of a server – how do you balance your own vision for the server from before it started with the assumed visions of the players? How can you make sure the decisions demanded by the players are recognised without allowing them to make choices that (in your view) harm the server? Is it possible to increase the popularity of your server without assimilating with the ever-growing number of servers who all have one, stubborn, goal in their mind – increasing player count?

[a] I recognise that this is an unsupported claim.

In order to answer these questions, you must understand the two weights in play in any multiplayer server – the view of the players and the view of the server owner.[a] If the two views are visualised as a two-circle Venn diagram, the area of their intersection can be thought of as the amount of flexibility an owner has in making decisions – how much of their own circle they can pick ideas out of. This intersection also represents the views that both the Owner and the Players have in common.

However, these are *weights*, meaning that they also possess another property – their physical mass – or, how important they are perceived to be. This perception can be held by the server owner regarding players, meaning how much of the players' opinions are taken into account when deciding server mechanics, for example. This can also be a perception held by the players themselves – whether they feel they have a voice in making decisions.

Four possible situations arise from these two factors which I shall deal with independently:

1. Large intersection of views[b] + High weight of player opinion
2. Large intersection of views + Low weight of player opinion
3. Low intersection of views + High weight of player opinion
4. Low intersection of views + Low weight of player opinion

The first case is the optimal case in a hierarchical server – the server owner is satisfied that their direction for the server lines up with their player base's opinion, and they are open to taking the players' views in consideration when making decisions.

One may argue that the second term is a direct cause of the first term. In other words, because the owner has a large number of views in common with their players, it is much easier for the owner to accept them as peers. Although this view seems straightforward and natural, the two terms are completely independent from each other. Take the example of a server owner whose direction for their server is popular among the player base but who does not actively listen to them, instead making decisions independently – it is simply coincidental that the owner's actions align with the players' wants.

The above situation would be representative of the second case – a lot in common, but the owner acts independently. It is also important to note that these terms are fluid – an owner who has a lot in common with their players at the establishment of the server may not hold the same values or vision for the server after a few months of operation; similarly, an owner who is receptive to feedback at the start may later find their player base acting rashly, and thus, decrease the weight on player opinion when making decisions.

The third case is of a humble and open owner – although their vision is unaligned with their players', they are still open to feedback and advice. These owners listen to

[a] In some servers, this may also be the view of the admins, or even moderators. In any case, I refer to the person, or group of people, who have power to make decisions about the server.

[b] That is, of the server owner and the players.

their players attentively and are usually the ones who are thought of most highly by the players and considered "one of the people", creating an equal environment where all views are respected.

One may argue here that the third case is the optimum. Firstly, despite the differences in opinion, the owner continues to take the players' perspectives into account; thus, this must be the case where the most respect is given – even more than the first case, as the respect in that case may be fragile. Further, the owner being amicable with their player base, and the players being amicable with the owner, must mean that a more positive community is built.

To explain why both arguments fail – or why both positions remain rather *inefficient* for the goal of player satisfaction – we must consider them in relation to the goal of a server.

What is the purpose of a Minecraft server? Or even, what *is* a Minecraft server?

I will define a server (that is, not *only* an SMP, e.g., anarchy, geopol) for the purposes of the following sections as follows:

> A multiplayer environment where people involved in the environment, be it as a moderator or player, work towards a goal that they individually have. This may be a shared goal, a formally recognised and rigid goal, or even an informal goal such as "fun". An "environment" could refer to a Survival world with the Nether and End locked, or a Creative server with building plots.

Ultimately, servers have a loose goal – and for an SMP, which this paper deals with – this is *fun*. The exact definition of fun is not important here, but the fact that this subjective goal remains desired is of importance.[a]

There are a few things that must be understood to realise the flawed nature of one figure ruling over an entire server.

Firstly, recognise that *players* play on a server. Even if the owner plays on the server, they can also be thought of as a player. The subjective goal of fun needs to be agreed upon by the majority of the players in order to maximise the amount of fun that any particular individual may have. This is usually done through discussion between players either within the server environment itself (in-game) or through external forums, such as Discord.

Secondly, understand that the players *themselves* will know best about what *they* want. Even when given a private, honest space to share their opinions, some players will still feel anxious about dissenting against the Owner, whom they perceive as "all-knowing".

Further, no amount of oversight or observation by the owner may be able to represent *all* player opinions. Even if the owner plays on the server regularly and engages with the community as a normal player, they will still have a skewed or biased view of the

[a]Note that *fun* and *satisfaction* are not the same idea. *Fun* is a broad and generally undefined word used to describe a "vibe" players get when they are feeling *satisfied* on a server. Because it is unspecific and relating to an *emotion*, I separate these.

server. There is also the question of differential treatment by players towards the owner when they are playing, which will also exaggerate the positive aspects of the players and diminish the negative ones.

One can argue that if the owner plays on an "alt account", they will be able to get a true experience on the server; however, this will also produce a biased result depending on the owner's own play style, influencing whom they interact with.

Thirdly, many players often put forward suggestions for changing a server by discussing them among themselves, then bringing those suggestions forward to the owner – usually through more influential or well-known players who may have sway over the owner. However, this is an inefficient way of creating change.

Fourthly, even if the owner always does approve of all suggestions, there may be disagreement in the implementation of the suggestions. An owner will always have a skewed view of their server, as mentioned above, due to their status and role in the power hierarchy. This may have the effect of creating more harm than good, as the players could feel that their desires are not being fulfilled – but at the same time, the owner can develop a perception that their work is not being valued and that implementing player suggestions is a waste of time.[a] Consequently, this creates a negative feedback loop that causes the area of intersection between the Owner and the Players to shrink, leading to the opinion of the Players being given less weight, until the point where the two classes are completely polarised and players begin to leave.

Having considered these points, one can still find a commonality between them – which is that all decisions could be made by the owner. One may suggest that this results in quick, efficient decision-making and less bureaucracy, allowing players to experience server changes more quickly and accelerating the feedback loop.[b] This may also mean that players have a higher likelihood (due to how frequently opportunities to show agency arise) of feeling satisfaction. All processes have trade-offs, and this example is one that we must deal with.

In order to please players and restore their power, inefficiency is a necessary evil. As we've established, only players know best what they want in a server, and any other person or group of people making decisions *for* them in the name of "knowing better" is *more* inefficient as it will not deliver a satisfactory result and will require more iterations of the feedback loop – this is compared to the often tedious and long-drawn nature of discussion and collective decision making, but it almost always guarantees a more satisfactory result.

The fact that players collectively make these decisions also means that discussions can be more civil as every person has equal amounts of power, sharing a unifying goal that is constructive – compared to the unifying, but unhelpfully critical, goal that players may have against the owner.

[a] Of course, not every owner will think the same. However, for the purposes of this paper, I shall use a generalisation of the worst-case-scenario where applicable.

[b] The feedback loop is the following: problem → solution identified → change → player feedback → (repeat)

One could construct a strong argument that setting up a new server and establishing new leadership can provide an entirely clean slate for a more stable form of leadership. One fault in this argument is that the players' emotional attachment to the world remains overlooked. This means a brand-new world must be created. Players must re-establish relationships, create new cultural landmarks, and invent new in-jokes about the server. This process is physically exhausting, mentally exhausting, and most importantly: it decreases satisfaction monumentally.

Further, I believe the revolution (so to say) of the Players against the Owner can deliver even more satisfaction than resetting everything. Server cultures stay in place, relationships remain stable (if not reinforced), and the world stays the same. If, eventually, the Players do overthrow the Owner, a new vibrant culture of daily discussion – which players know will at least not be a waste of time – can drive players' motivation to play and participate on the server. This is in contrast to there being an issue on a server with a Traditional structure, where a player may try to create change before ultimately giving up.

4.4 Reclaiming player power

The players' power can, and must be, *reclaimed*. The system of operating a server where this is achieved is the *Co-operative* system.

Due to the already established monopoly of the Owner over the Players, it is essential that the Players unite against the Owner. There must be no doubt between players that what they are against is an (almost) immovable force who has control over *their* server and *their* community. The Players must realise that as long as they have an owner, their feelings of agency will be capped at a certain level due to the presence of an immovable obstacle to gaining ultimate collective power.

This is where *celebrity players* come in – these people have the most agency (as they already know that they are popular amongst other players), and the most power (as they are also recognised *personally* by the owner), which allows them to influence both the classes effectively. The influence they perform leads to increased feelings of agency, which in turn also boosts their own satisfaction – which can lead to a positive feedback loop, allowing them to influence the owner even more.

I envision this to be a long, tedious, and very difficult process: when you try to dispel the myth of "efficiency" and "wisdom" of the Owner to a recipient who has only ever known the status-quo, you will meet great resistance. However, once much of the Players have been educated about these matters, they should constantly and without hesitation repeat the same, commonly agreed-upon message of disapproval to show their unity against the Owner. The Players shall force the Owner to be removed and immediately set up concrete infrastructure within the Discord server (or other means of communication) to establish the following as a minimum:[a]

[a]Please keep in mind that this should not be taken as a fully planned out manifesto – this paper simply lays the foundation for its necessity.

1. An open, free, and respectful space for debate and discussion
2. Direct voting on server mechanics, which can be initiated by any player
3. An Executive Council chosen by lottery to implement approved changes

The first is essential for any Player-owned server, as the basis of the entire concept is for players to be able to discuss amongst themselves and enact change directly to other members of the same class; a safe space for all players to participate in this process is absolutely necessary. This space must be inclusive of all and do its best to give equal weight and time to all voices, no matter how famous, influential, or veteran. However, at the same time, members of the Executive Council must not be able to participate in debate, and they must be politically neutral because of their role, which requires them to be disinterested and unbiased parties whose job is simply to *carry out* the agreed-upon wishes of the Players.

This will also cement the fact that agency and satisfaction are the primary goals of a co-operative server. If players feel that they are able to drive change (and if they truly can drive change), they will feel like they have *agency*. Similarly, if there is a lower barrier to enjoying oneself on the server, satisfaction will come about more easily.

The second of the three-legged stool allows for the results of these debates to be carried out. Direct voting means that every player's vote is equal and meaningful. Decisions by referendum also avoid the problem that ultimately rises from using a representative system, which gives certain players an elevated position, mimicking the Owner. The latter part of this point enshrines the equal right and power of every player to be able to create change. In terms of agency and power, this reaffirms both.

This right also creates opportunities for abuse and trolling, as a newly joined troll has the exact same power as a two-year veteran. However, this right is essential to maintain a "no exceptions" culture when it comes to having the right to say something is wrong, and to change it, starting from oneself. To address this risk, a simple majority vote could be conducted, serving as a preliminary check before continuing to debate a proposed issue or solution.

The final point ensures that the debates held were not pointless and that a team of regular players – not a dictatorial entity like the Owner – will carry out the practical steps needed implement a new change. This Executive Council is chosen by lottery, meaning that it is not disproportionately filled with self-sorting players who may have a certain bias or obsession with the server's operations, making them *interested* parties and likely ineffective at being unbiased when carrying out the necessary, practical work. This also serves as a safeguard against corruption, as the players who bring a proposal to the Council cannot influence it without knowing *who* is on the Council.

A random chance of being on the Council also means that a culture of equality is established. Because serving on it is normalised, players begin to feel like part of a political culture where everyone *is* truly *seen* and *treated* as equal.

4.5 Caveat for this system

It is important to note that, just like many server proposals, one that focuses on restoring agency and power may not always be the best for the players. Take the example of a Vanilla UHC server – there are a set of rules, some mods, and everything else is set in stone. Not only are the Players' opinions not heard or cared about, but they are not given any weight either. The established culture within the server is that "it is what it is", and making changes is irrelevant. The prevailing view is that a server built on survival, competition, PvP, and defending your base does not require players to get involved with *how* it is managed.

Although total disregard for player feedback remains rare, servers with concrete and specific goals face a significant challenge. It is difficult to justify introducing player-led decision-making on these servers, even regarding peripheral issues where the players might actually make better decisions.

4.6 Conclusion

In this paper, we've discussed existing hierarchical structures of leadership, player satisfaction regarding agency and power, and the intersections of Player and Owner views. We also assessed how much weight these views hold for the Owner and provided a template for how Players can take back ownership of their servers.

4.7 Acknowledgements

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4.8 Declarations

No conflict of interest and no AI use have been declared.